

Standard Chartered Plc (HK) (2888)

>15% RoTE by 2028 in line, but capital return target may slightly disappoint; reiterate OW

STAN's >15% RoTE target by 2028E is broadly in line with JPMe (15.5%), but with expectations having built up - particularly following the strong 1Q print - we expect a muted to slightly negative near-term share price reaction. That said, STAN has been conservative in target-setting, focusing on beating rather than stretching expectations. We reiterate our OW rating on STAN, as the sustainable growth plan underpins a double-digit EPS CAGR trajectory delivering RoTE expansion from 11.9% in 2025 to >15% in 2028 and then ~18% by 2030. We believe the current valuation of 1.2x 26E P/B does not reflect these long-term ROTE targets and we await further details to assess.

- **What's been announced?** STAN has set out sustainable growth plan, comprising: **1)** RoTE of >15% by 2028 (a >3pp uplift from 2025), building to ~18% by 2030; **2)** a high-teens EPS CAGR and a 5-7% income CAGR over 2025-2028; **3)** a cost-to-income ratio of ~57% by 2028 (from 63% in 2025), supported by positive income-to-cost jaws; **4)** ~20% improvement in income per employee by 2028, with corporate functions headcount reduction of >15% by 2030; **5)** a CET1 ratio operating range of 13-14% and through-the-cycle loan loss ratio of 30-35bps; **6)** a dividend payout ratio of ≥30% with progressive DPS; and **7)** \$200bn of Net New Money, and Affluent income to reach 75% of its total by 2028 (accelerated from 2029). In addition, STAN announced the appointment of Manus Costello as Group CFO, subject to regulatory approval ([link](#)), effective immediately on an interim basis. Manus joined STAN in April 2024 as Global Head of Investor Relations, having previously spent 25 years in equity research, including as a founding partner and Global Head of Research at Autonomous.

- **Comparison with JPMe - broadly inline. Positive:** 1) RoTE building to ~18% by 2030 is a newly announced target. **Inline:** 1) >15% RoTE in 2028 (vs JPMe 15.5%); 2) 2025-2028 income CAGR of 5-7% (vs JPMe 5.5%); 3) high-teens EPS CAGR (vs JPMe 18.6%). **Miss:** 1) No change to the CET1 target range at 13-14% (vs the JPMe of a narrower 13-13.5%), though this does not impact our buyback estimate (\$2bn/2.5bn/2.5bn in 2026/27/28E) as our 26e to 28e CET1 ratios are 13.6%/13.7%/13.8%, within the guided range. 2) 2028 CIR of ~57% (vs JPMe 56%). 3) No updated 2026 NII guidance, despite market expectations of an upward revision following the strong 1Q trajectory.
- **We expect a muted to slightly negative share price reaction in the near term:** The FY28 ROTE target of >15% is in line with the JPMe and company-compiled consensus, which stood at 15.1% before the 1Q release and has likely been revised up following the strong 1Q print. However, the market may view the capital management target as a slight miss, given the lack of buyback guidance and no revision to the CET1

Overweight

2888.HK, 2888 HK

Price: HK\$196.60

18 May 2026

Price Target: HK\$275.00

PT End Date: 31 Dec 2026

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target range. We expect the stock to stay flattish or edge slightly lower when the market opens.

Table 1: Summary of STAN's medium-term target vs JPMe

Key metrics	STAN's medium term target	JPMe
Stated ROTE	>15% in 2028, and building to ~18% in 2030	15.5% in 2028
EPS CAGR (25-28E)	High-teens CAGR	18.6% CAGR
Revenue CAGR (25-28E)	5-7% CAGR	5.5% CAGR
Cost-to-income ratio	~57% in 2028	~56% in 2028
Productivity improvements	Raise income per employee by ~20% by 2028, and reduction in corporate functions roles of >15% by 2030	NA
CET1 operating range	13-14%	Narrowed to 13-13.5%
Loan loss ratio	30-35bps through-the-cycle	NA
Dividend payout	30% or more, with progressive DPS	35% payout ratio
WRB business	Targeting \$200bn of Net New Money, and Affluent income to reach 75% of its total by 2028 (from 2029)	NA

Source: Company report, J.P. Morgan estimates.

Investment Thesis

We view StanChart as undervalued relative to the sector/EM peers at 1.3x PTNAV 27E with significant earnings growth potential supported by structural growth drivers and relatively high capital return. With the Group's 24-26E targets already achieved by FY25 across revenues and distributions, we forecast ~6% revenue CAGR across '25-28E driven by non-NII in '26E, and broadening out to both NII/non-NII in outer years. We see this led by Wealth (driven by Affluent segment opportunities), Financial Markets (alongside cross-border income) and Banking. We expect NII to be largely flat in FY26 y/y due to lower rates and pass throughs offset by volume growth. We expect a ~1% cost CAGR for '25-28E as we expect growing investments in the future to capitalize on productivity and revenue opportunities, with positive operating leverage annually and the CIR to decline towards mid-50s. Overall, we expect stated ROTE to grow to ~15%, alongside a 35% dividend payout ratio and \$2-2.5bn/y buybacks, offering a total yield of 7-9%/y. Maintain OW.

Valuation

Our Dec-26 PT of HK\$275 is derived from our DDM analysis with NAV discounted back to Dec-26 from FY28E and a fair P/B of 1.5x. Our key assumptions are a normalized ROE of 12.1% and a cost of capital of 9.3%.

Risks to Rating and Price Target

The key downside risks to our rating and price target include:

- **Macroeconomic risks:** Being an EM-focused bank, StanChart is exposed to general macroeconomic risk in EM such as slowdowns, inflationary pressures, depreciation of EM currencies and cross-border and political risks. Potential weakness in China macro and regional sovereign continue to be risks towards revenues and impairments in the near term, as well as geopolitical tensions creating a potential headwind.
- **Provisioning outlook:** We expect provisions to grow to above normalized levels by 2025 given growing pressures in the economic environment. An increase or decrease in provisions as a result of the economic outlook or with regards to specific cases poses a risk to our forecasts.
- **Regulatory uncertainty:** Standard Chartered remains exposed to the changes in the regulatory environment in the UK with capital requirements being set by the PRA in the UK. While StanChart has limited UK exposure, the group is still subject to regulatory changes such as Basel 4 and BoE stress tests.

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Standard Chartered Plc (HK) (2888) (2888.HK, 2888 HK) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Sep 24, 2002. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

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